

The Key

version 1

This copy carries no dedication.

Contents

1. The Key

The people and the places

Characters

No characters in this novel.

Places

No places in this novel.

The story

For forty-four years, Tomás tended the lighthouse at Cabo Fisterra, at the edge of the Costa da Morte where the Atlantic meets the last stone of Galicia. On the morning of his retirement in September 2026, the key to the lamp room passes to his son Manuel. But the habit does not leave him: the climb up the stone steps, the ninety-two to the gallery, the fourteen more to the light, the pull of the tower above the village that turns its back to the wind.

Rosa, his wife of forty years, has built a life within the life the lighthouse demanded. Manuel, born the year after the great Atlantic storm of October 1987, watches his father with the particularity of a man who has never understood the silence between them. That storm—when Tomás wound the rotating optic by hand through the night and held five fishing boats in his beam while the mainland could not reach him—lives unspoken in the house, a weight carried without words.

In the greenhouse behind his stone house, Tomás saves seed from his tomatoes in labelled jars, year after year. And now, with the watch formally ended, these small, precise habits of a lifetime take on a different weight. This is a novel about the quiet work of love, about lighthouses and storms, about what we keep and what we carry in silence.

For readers of *The Light Between Oceans*, *The Remains of the Day* and *Beside the Ocean of Time*.

Chapter 1 — The Key

The alarm in his body woke him before the clock, as it had for forty-four years. He dressed in the dark by habit. Rosa turned in sleep and away.

The lighthouse path was steep. He climbed the ninety-two steps without pausing, hand on the worn rail. At the gallery he stopped—still black, dawn an hour away. Then fourteen more steps to the lamp room.

He stopped at the door and knew he would not come back. His watch ends today. He wound the rotating optic anyway, his hand remembering the resistance, turning the ground glass on its bed of mercury. The motor took over, the light turning through the pattern his hand had traced for four decades, now without him.

In the keeper's office, he opened the watch log to the blank page. He turned back through decades in his own handwriting. October 1987 came without searching. He had opened this book that night, his hand steady enough to write.

Wind NW severe to violent. Supply failed 2100 hrs. Hand-wound rotating optic 2100–0600 hrs every hour. Five vessels sheltering in beam.

The words sat factual as stone. The memory was in the ink, but it would not be spoken. He wrote the new entry—the retirement entry—and closed the book.

The greenhouse held yesterday's warmth. His tomato plants had entered their final growth. He moved through the rows planted in March, selecting the ripest ones. His knife cut the fruits, removed the seeds to cloth, rinsed them, laid them to dry. In brown ink steady as his log-hand, he labeled each jar: *Tomate de Peniche, 2026. Corazón de Buey, 2026*. These seeds would be his proof that he could make something grow from what was already his own.

The Sunday meal was at two. Rosa had made the stew and bread from the panadería. Manuel sat across, eyes watching the table. When the conversation settled where it always did, when the pause came where the pause always came, Tomás opened his mouth to tell the joke about the octopus and the accountant. He told it in the same words he had always told it, every Sunday the same. Manuel's face readied itself before the punchline. Rosa's mouth went wry at the familiar phrase. The ritual held.

After the meal, he and Manuel walked up the lighthouse path. The sun was low and red, running out of the western sea. In the lamp room, as the rotating optic began to turn in the gathering darkness, Tomás reached beside the lamp and removed the key. He placed it into Manuel's hand.

He did not speak. His son closed his hand around the cold metal.